

Introduction

Decision-making and problem solving processes are closely related, yet are distinct cognitive processes. Problem-solving requires the individual to formulate a means of overcoming an obstacle where no suitable solution is apparent. Conversely, decision making processes require the individual to select between available alternatives. Both of these processes place demands on the prefrontal cortex, a part of the frontal lobe of the brain. Collins and Koechlin (2012) identify the frontal lobes, particularly the prefrontal cortex, as central to reasoning and adaptive decision-making.

This reflective assignment examines two separate personal experiences: the important decision to move away from England, as well as explaining a significant problem that I subsequently tried to overcome. Each scenario will initially be described clearly. Finally, I will utilise frameworks found from within this unit's modules to ascertain if a more productive or more effective decision could have been formulated.

Important Decision: Moving to Another Country

Original Decision-Making Process

A significant decision I made was to leave the UK and establish myself abroad. I was optimistic that relocating would improve my quality of life, however this singular hope was not the main catalyst behind this decision. Throughout childhood, and my siblings' early years we all had to tolerate persistent physical and emotional abuse from both of our parents. My father frequently became extremely aggressive and violent. Whilst hopeful of support from our mother during his many attacks, we found that she often responded to our cries for help with equal hostility.

Some memorable incidents occurred when my father returned home intoxicated and entered the bedroom that I shared with my two brothers. When one of my brothers did not respond quickly enough, my father struck him in the face, damaging his front teeth. As a result of that, both of his upper central incisor teeth of the upper jaw were knocked out. Panicking after seeing the blood I yelled frantically to my mother from the top of the staircase, only to be told to shut up or I was going to be next. Moments later, my father grabbed me by the hair, dragged me downstairs and physically assaulted me in the kitchen.

Experiences like this convinced me that the family home was neither safe nor emotionally supportive and I needed to establish a safer living situation.

Module-Informed Decision-Making Process

If I could reconsider this decision using knowledge from the module, I would approach it more systematically while recognising that leaving an abusive environment was a legitimate objective. Despite reaching adulthood, fear still played its part as did the strong desire to create significant distance from the family household.

Using Halpern's critical thinking framework, I would first define my plan and goals more precisely achieving safety and space a flourish with independence. My reasoning may also have been influenced by framing, and confirmation bias as I associated associated remaining within the UK would mean that effectively I was still within arms reach,

Thus making the move abroad all the more compelling. Confirmation bias may also have led me to focus on positive prospects about life abroad, drowning out the reality of serious matters such as unemployment, social isolation, financial pressure, cultural adjustment and housing. To reduce this bias, I would deliberately seek evidence both supporting and challenging my relocation plan.

Finally, I may attempt to use a weighted decision matrix (WDM), a tool employed in decision-making for comparing different options based on several criteria, each with its own level of importance (Pukała et al., 2020). Safety would have been my number one priority but each other factor, including residency, social support, financial stability would have all been added to the relocation theory, admittedly even unfavorable results, I would likely have still left. I was at my wits end.

Comparison and Reflection

My original-decision making process was fuelled primarily by the urgent desire to get out of that toxic and abusive household as well as distance myself from my family, as for some reason we all grew up hating one another and backstabbing wherever possible. Although the decision for me did work and I finally found a greater deal of independence, I took a very risky gamble that could easily have backfired, as I made the decision with limited considerations and insufficient alternative options. Realistically, a module based may have offered me improved financial, legal and cultural preparation for my major transition in life.

Significant problem : Self-Harming Crisis and Medical Intervention

After relocating from the United Kingdom and distancing myself from a harmful family environment, I subsequently for unknown reasons, developed serious issues with self harm as well as strong feelings of self-directed anger. During the early stages, I was able to conceal the wounds from friends and staff members.

Although a doctor was aware, this doctor was a marriage counseling doctor, he was treating my wife and myself regarding depression, I again for unknown reasons opted not to disclose the severity of my problems nor what I was doing at home when I was alone with a knife. I attempted and believed in myself that I could manage and improve the situation without seeking sufficient professional support from doctors. Especially since during those early stages I was not fluent in speaking and understanding Chinese.

For reasons I cannot fathom, I ended up having another episode, however this time, I went too far, resulting in a significantly more serious situation than I had expected. However, I remained calm, positive that I could fix this before anyone noticed. Unfortunately, I was mistaken and one of my colleagues, a former nurse, helped me to slow the bleeding. The downside was that I needed to give reasons as to how this problem occurred.

This whole ordeal highlighted the limitations of my original methodology of cutting and concealing, moreover, by purposefully withholding important information from doctors and colleagues, I prevent them all from trying to help me sooner, or even see the signs that I was falling into that state, a very dangerous and foolish move on my part.

Module-Informed Problem-Solving Process

If I could approach my problem again using what I have learned from the module, I believe that I note that self-harm should not be a private matter, concealing it from others, means that they never know you are in pain or you are struggling so they may continue on increases your stress levels or may not reduce your workloads as they have no clue what's really happening, I had this mindset because I did not want the embarrassment of appearing weak.

Using Newell and Simon's problem-space framework, noted by Bianchini (2026) as a cognitive psychology monograph on the information processing approach to human problem solving I would identify the self-harming urges, recognise the severity and open communication channels to the appropriate professionals at the very first opportunity, possible actions would include being fully transparent with the doctor and perhaps requesting them to refer me to a mental health specialist,

and perhaps inviting a very close family friend or trusted person do that things can be de-escalated before they get out of hand.

Means–end analysis could help divide the difference between the initial and desired states into manageable subgoals, the GPS was defined by CIQ Team (2023) as a paradigm implemented as a computer program in Newell and Simon's General Problem Solver (GPS). Employing this, would mean that the first subgoal would be to seek immediate safety, possibly visiting a clinic or mental health professional when necessary.

The second goal would be about honest disclosure, including the frequency that I hurt myself and announce anything that I feel could be triggers or warning signs.

Applying the module knowledge to this would therefore be open and honest about the issue, replace the secrecy and concealing mindset with seeking appropriate help, thought this step may also not rid myself of the problem entirely, it puts me in a better position health wise as, using blades opens the door to all kinds of skin, and blood infection. I do not think I am looking to get those.

Comparison and Reflection

My approach relied heavily on secrecy. Sadly my actions of not informing the doctor or seeking out a psychiatrist, meant that I got help far later than I really needed it. From the module, I am now able to make a module based informed approach which would define my problems more clearly, and split the problem between professionals, one for identifying the trigger within my mind, and one for the administration of medicines to help stabilize my mood patterns, Overall, applying a structured problem-solving technique would likely have reduced the danger, improved communication and enabled earlier intervention.

Conclusion

The scenarios demonstrate important differences between intuitive and module-informed thinking. My decision to relocate was influenced by an urgent desire for safety, while my response to self-harm relied on concealment and delayed help-seeking. Applying critical-thinking and problem-solving frameworks may have encouraged clearer goals, wider alternatives, balanced evaluation and earlier professional intervention. These methods could not guarantee successful outcomes, they in gage have only made both processes more systematic, transparent and safer.

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Appendix 1

Written argument from module 5 (I could not locate a place to submit it.)

Formative Case Study: Analysing a Flawed Argument

AI in Education – A Guiding Light or Destroyer of Individuality?

Introduction

Artificial Intelligence (AI) should not be demonized or scrutinized with skeptical and enviously jealous eyes. As new generations, concepts, and technology arise, the world is always changing. One of the most significant recent advancements is artificial intelligence, which presents both significant opportunities and significant ethical challenges.

AI is just that, an evolutionary leap in technological advancement, as noted by Jurewicz et al. (2024) they are technologies that have an increasingly significant influence on a variety of human endeavors. Catering to numerous fields, including healthcare, material science, infrastructure engineering, social media, surveillance technology, and even artistic expression. Essentially it is an assistant, a guide, a friendly reminder, a tool that can systematically support ideas, actions, theories, or highlight critically overlooked or under-evaluated viewpoints during essay structuring, persuasive or argumentative journal compositions and so on.

Benefits of AI

At face value, it could be argued that AI is an unfairly, highly advantageous tool that the newer generations have access to that previous generations of students and learners did not. That means that one could say without much scrutiny or negative feedback that having this new, technologically advanced algorithm aid them, highlight their overlooked scenarios, pinpoint weaknesses in their written arguments or theories would have been a significant and highly beneficial aid to as well, should it have been available.

However, this advantage was not conceived of during those previous periods as other technological matters were being thought up and developed. I tell myself all of the time that the world is becoming a better place as every minute passes and new knowledge is discovered, shared and integrated into society, now AI has been conceived, there is no telling where or how far it may go in the evolution of other technologies.

That is not to say however that AI is perfect and without flaws and various types of functionality failures, and as a consequence is not a feature that should be implemented unequivocally without caution as its algorithms and generative abilities have some obvious drawbacks, such as inaccuracies in some of its yielded responses and concepts or theories it provides may not be absolute, and therefore its findings need to be proven and backed up by scientific or other factual findings to ensure the results it provides are not riddled with inaccuracies (Raji et al., 2022).

Dangers of Over-reliance

The second largest drawback, possibly one of the worst, is over-reliance. According to research by Zhai et al. (2024), over-reliance compromises important cognitive abilities like critical thinking and may lead to an excessive dependence on AI for future tasks. Meaning that when users allow for the distractions of life around them to diminish their time actively taking part in studies and rely on the algorithm to write assignments entirely for them because they either no longer have sufficient time, or lack the interest to tackle the challenge laid out before them.

This over-reliance, quickly introduces increased dangers of plagiarism, and larger scale problematic academic consequences due to dishonesty and deliberate sabotage of a vital fundamentally sound educational establishment that has grown and been redefined and improved over the centuries. So whilst AI is gaining traction in the current climate, something newer or more advanced may yet succeed it, highlighting yet another stage in the ever progressing evolution of knowledge and intelligence growth.

However, with that being said, it should be pointed out that the availability and ease of access means that AI is easily and readily available to millions of individuals, resulting in it integrating its way through educational establishments and universities significantly faster than perhaps anyone could have foreseen or prepared for. Leaving it perfectly at the intersection of a dual use dilemma, as it carries with it the duality of being both an empowerment aid or a serious existential threat to the academic integrity as many students may begin to employ it in a passive way to avoid critical thinking and general attempts at understanding presented literature and dodging the time and effort required to establish resolutions to genuine problems within certain fields of study.

AI Tools are Not Neutral

Another key issue to the use and application of AI is the worry regarding privacy and transparency, which understandably raises significant ethical questions. Circling back to a time before the development of AI, and to students studying in areas that are unfortunately located in black spots

for WiFi or internet access, AI may introduce or unintentionally expose and give access to unequal and highly unfair educational advantages, as it provides almost immediate access to a learning chat-bot, able to resolve complex problems, mathematical equations and programming languages within seconds.

As well as not being inherently neutral, certain concerns have also been raised regarding the collection of sensitive students information, including geographical locations, age, race and particularly studies of interest, this is not an isolated incident and most AI-driven data collecting methods present ethical and legal issues, with an emphasis on advancements from 2023 to 2024. The complex relationship between privacy protection and technological innovation developments in AI have both increased and created new ethical issues as the years have progressed (Mirishli, 2024).

Arguments For and Against

Many educators, professors and educational policy makers may point out that the simplest and safest option would be to ban artificial intelligence use from education entirely. A viewpoint that many would stand behind and support for numerous reasons, going beyond the most obvious. This however may be something no longer as simple as it sounds. Whilst it is arguably acceptable to say that AI can generate a lot of inaccuracies within its yielded answers, it is now almost indistinguishable aside from the use of other technology or software algorithms to determine whether cheating has actually taken place and whether academic consequences are justifiably thrown at an individual, as it is very difficult to say without one hundred percent certainty that a student genuinely did not make those mistake themselves.

On the flip side to this simplest and safest option of simply banning the use of AI from education, it may be unjustifiable and unethical to simply try to educate students that its use is somewhat unforgivable and unrealistic, especially since we now live in a world where this sort of technologically advanced systems already exist in numerous workplaces. As with a lot of newer assistive technologies, from a personal standpoint, I must concede that I am favorable toward the use of AI only in so much as it can make certain situations easier to resolve, such as quick tips on how to cook a specific food, how it can provide useful information for survivalist equipment to keep in the car and so on. I am less so favorable however for its use in medical situations and people self diagnosing themselves based on what they are feeling and what they tell the program, they make themselves susceptible to false diagnosis and complicate a matter that potentially could already be complicated in its own right.

Practical Solution

The practical solution or strategic standpoints towards technological advancements such as artificial intelligence should not be that of instant acceptance or straight out rejection. Rather institutions should perhaps try to adopt a more holistic approach to the ever advancing technological world that we live in. The same way that laptops and personal computer systems and tablets have been scrutinized at some point within their early developmental stages, to today's evaluated and approved standpoints as being acceptable in most educational environments, as they like modern AI are indeed able to make educational learning environments more engaging and stimulating in one way or another.

What perhaps should be developed to reduce over-reliance, overuse and the diminishment of independent critical thought synaptic functions within the minds of learners is the development of clear policies regarding fair use of the system and perhaps the introduction of supplementary

learning materials whereby students would be required to demonstrate specifically how they came to a particular conclusion or how they were able to systematically weed out incorrect answers with justifications until they achieved or found the correct answers by which reasoning supports their findings. AI should be used in the same manner as a calculator, applied or utilized when double checking figures or arithmetic, only in this sense it can also fact check, cross-reference and tighten up academic writing structures and methodologies, it should not be a substitute for independent thought and independent conclusions or independent critical thinking cultures.

Conclusion

Overall AI within the realms of education is not an enemy, not a system intended to undermine teachers or faculty staff, it is like a medicinal medicine offering relief and support to struggling students unable to reach or get in touch with teachers owing to time differences in different demographic areas, or for those encountering mental mind blocks or brain fog, unable to establish an angle to attack a certain given assignment. Institutions would benefit from welcoming AI, and teaching students to use it responsibly and in ways that promote their own critical thought and how utilizing tools to enhance their ideas could benefit them.

Methods

During the development of this blog article, I decided to adopt many of the techniques from reading passages with the intention to formulate a balanced, hybrid, yet persuasive argument, that could highlight some of the negative aspects of this technological wonder, as well as highlight areas that it could really be used to create a positive impression on learners outlooks towards learning, especially with many of them knowing that help or advice is within arms reach at any time of the day.

I did my best to avoid articles that focused on people developing relationships or what I consider in my own opinion as a bad habit with AI, treating it more than it is, and forming what can only be identified as obsessive unnatural scenarios spiraling out of control. I focused my attention on the security the bots offered, I discovered horror stories where lives had been lost due to AI interaction, and concluded to myself that further protocols needed to be integrated to these systems once they had detected irregular or unstable patterns in a persons conversational dialogue.

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